Table 3.2 Methods to reduce loss of nutrients while cooking vegetables.

Action	Reason
Cut the vegetable into bigger pieces.	Exposure of the vitamins to water is less.
Cut the vegetables and use it immediately.	Vitamin C is lost on exposure to air.
Soaking or washing time should be reduced. Wash the vegetable with the skin and later should be peeled and cut.	Enough time is not given for the water soluble nutrients to get dissolved in water.
Vegetables should be cooked in minimum amount of water. Any liquid remaining after cooking the vegetable should be used in a gravy or soup.	Water soluble nutrients are lost in the cooking liquid.
Cook vegetables wherever possible with the skin.	Leaching of vitamins into the water would be less.
Cook the vegetables by steaming and pressure cooking.	No additional water is added.
Do not add sodium bicarbonate while cooking	Nutrients are destroyed in an alkaline medium.
Cook for a minimum time, using a tight fitting lid.	Prolonged heating increases vitamin loss.
Green leafy vegetables should be washed well and then cut.	Water soluble nutrients are lost if the the vegetables are washed after cutting them
Greens should be cooked in open pans.	Greens when cooked in closed pans lose the natural green colour.

3.5.2 Role of vegetables in cookery

Vegetables are used universally in all recipes. They are used

- in curries, salads and in sambar
- as garnishing agents eg. shredded carrot and coriander leaves
- as stuffing in samosa and parathas
- as thickening agents in gravies and soups
- in chutneys (onion) and pickles (tomato, onion)
- as part of recipes like pulao, avial and non-vegetarian dishes
- as preserved foods like vathal in the dehydrated form.

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